BY ORDER OF THE SECRETARY OF THE AIR FORCE

HEADQUARTERS SPACE FORCE INSTRUCTION 36-2672

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Personnel

SKILLBRIDGE PROGRAM

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This publication implements United States Code (USC) 1143(e) *Employment Assistance* and Department of Defense Instruction (DoDI) 1322.29, *Job Training, Employment Skills Training, Apprenticeships, and Internships (JTEST-AI) for Eligible Service Members*. It assigns responsibilities, provides guidance, and prescribes procedures on the implementation, execution and management of the Space Force SkillBridge Program. It applies to uniformed members of the United States Space Force (USSF). Authorities to waive Delta/Squadron level requirements in this publication are identified with a Tier ("**T-0**, **T-1**, **T-2**, **T-3**") number following the compliance statement. See Department of the Air Force Manual 90-161, *Publishing Processes and Procedures,* Table A10.1 for a description of the authorities associated with Tier numbers. Submit requests for waivers through the chain of command to the appropriate Tier waiver approval authority, or alternately, to the Publication OPR for non-tiered compliance items. Ensure all records generated as a result of processes prescribed in this publication adhere to Air Force Instruction 33-322, *Records Management and Information Governance Program*, and are disposed in accordance with the Air Force Records Disposition Schedule, which is located in the Air Force Records Information Management System. The use, in this publication, of any non-Federal entity name, logo, trademark, commercial product or service, or training, certification and accreditation standards, does not constitute endorsement of the Department of Defense (DoD) or the Department of the Air Force (DAF).

SUMMARY OF CHANGES

This document provides guidance to USSF service members and separates from guidance to United States Air Force (USAF) service members in Air Force Instruction (AFI) 36-2671. Both documents replace Chapter 6, Section 6.10 of Department of the Air Force Instruction (DAFI) 36-2670_Interim Change 10, *Total Force Development*. It has been substantially revised and should be completely reviewed.

1. Overview:

1.1. **Purpose of SkillBridge:** The DoD SkillBridge Program assists eligible transitioning service members in gaining needed transferable skills and experience for their successful transition to civilian employment per Title 10 USC § 1143(e), *Employment Assistance*.

1.2. Space Force leaders ensure operational and command requirements are maintained.

2. Roles and Responsibilities.

2.1. **Headquarters (HQ) Space Force Deputy Chief of Space Operations for Personnel (SF/S1) through the Directorate of Force Development (SF/S1D) shall:**

2.1.1. Oversee policy, guidance, criteria, and budget requirements established by the Under Secretary of Defense for Personnel and Readiness (USD(P&R)).

2.1.2. Advocate for the Space Force SkillBridge Program and coordinate with the Assistant Secretary of the Air Force for Manpower and Reserve Affairs (SAF/MR) who provides secretarial oversight for policy development and implementation of legislative initiatives and with the Headquarters Space Force Deputy Chief of Space Operations for Personnel (SF/S1) who administers SkillBridge for Guardians.

2.1.3. Provide oversight and responsibility for the DoD and USSF policies, budget, program data and guidance implemented for the SkillBridge Program.

2.1.4. Coordinate with SkillBridge stakeholders on program related data requirements.

2.2. **The Air Force Personnel Center Business Process Owner (AFPC/DPPSA) shall:**

2.2.1. Oversee execution of the SkillBridge Program and develop applicable guidance.

2.2.2. Provide coordination with SF/S1D on policy, data requests, and process reviews to improve automation and support sustainment of the SkillBridge Program.

2.2.3. Provide oversight of the administrative support personnel responsible for reviewing and responding to inquiries from DoD authorized organizations, Service members, and commanders.

2.3. **The Education & Training Section Chief (E&TSC) shall:**

2.3.1. Provide basic advisement services and at least one monthly briefing on the SkillBridge Program policies and procedures.

2.3.2. Maintain documentation of all advisement sessions, briefings, and other SkillBridge associated actions in the Air Force Automated Education Management System (AFAEMS).

2.4. **The Responsible Commander (CC) shall:**

2.4.1. Serve as approval authority for SkillBridge applicants ensuring adherence to associated policies in DoD and DAF Instructions.

2.4.2. Conduct judicious SkillBridge application reviews, verify training acceptance, track service member’s accountability, and require exit survey data completion.

2.5. **The Responsible Supervisor shall:**

2.5.1. Discuss transition goals with subordinates and review SkillBridge Program applications for relevance and policy/procedure adherence.

2.5.2. Provide recommendations to command approval authority on SkillBridge Program requests to include suggested modifications to training plans.

2.5.3. Acknowledge backfills are not permitted for service members participating in SkillBridge Program and advise the appropriate command approval authority of operation and mission impacts of subsequent manpower deficits.

2.5.4. Advise SkillBridge participant their program can be terminated due to changing mission requirements, misconduct, lack of training progression, or if the service member decides to re-enlist or extend their current Service commitment.

2.5.5. Conduct weekly contacts with the subordinate and report any significant issues to leadership.

2.5.6. Conduct weekly contact with the training provider, monitor training progression, and report any deviations of the submitted training plan to leadership.

2.6. **Applicants shall:**

2.6.1. Conduct proper planning and preparation for their self-initiated SkillBridge Program that includes thorough review of applicable directives and required procedures.

2.6.2. Maintain weekly communication with their supervisor during participation in the SkillBridge Program.

3. SkillBridge Training Program Standards.

3.1. SkillBridge Programs must be offered by a DoD authorized organization with an approved Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) covering the duration of the training program and offer high probability of post-Service employment. **(T-0)**

3.2. Training must address a competency or skill gap the service member lacks that will directly contribute to their civilian employment/career goals. See **paragraph 4.3.7**. **(T-0)**

3.3. Training must be conducted in controlled environments that do not expose participants to hazardous situations with significant risk of bodily harm, illness, or death, nor place them in positions of perceived authority over civilians (e.g., front-line police officer, firefighter). In addition, training programs are not expected to directly financially benefit Provider's business interest as the primary focus of the program is to enhance the Applicant's suitability for future employment. **(T-0)**

3.4. Service members receive regular military pay and benefits and may not accept any form of compensation (wages, stipends, financial or monetary) from training providers. Applicants may accept employment benefits on par with other Provider employees (e.g. cafeteria benefits, gym membership, parking stipend) except for Domicile to Duty (workplace) transportation and only as expressly identified in the SkillBridge MoU. **(T-0)**

3.5. Training programs are offered at no cost for participating service members. **(T-0)**

3.6. Training programs approved by Veterans Affairs may be covered by the Service member's GI Bill benefits when such costs are explicitly identified in the SkillBridge MoU. **(T-0)**

3.7. Providers may reimburse any travel benefits including lodging, meal per diem, or travel costs, when offered to all similar training participants without regard to military affiliation and clearly identified by the provider on their SkillBridge DoD MoU application. **(T-0)**

3.8. Providers are not authorized to grant leaves of absence. Service members' leave requests will be routed through their chain of command, and duty status will be updated accordingly. **(T-1)**

4. Eligibility Requirements and General Guidance.

4.1. Service members must meet the following criteria to be eligible to participate in a SkillBridge Program. **(T-1)**

4.1.1. Complete at least 180 continuous days on active duty and expect to be discharged or released from their Service Component within 180 days of starting SkillBridge. **(T-0)** Exceptions are covered in **Paragraph 7.3** for service members pending medical board determination.

4.1.2. Be expected to separate from service with a characterization of general discharge (under honorable conditions) or higher. **(T-1)**

4.1.3. Initiate Transition Assistance Program (TAP) participation by completing individualized initial counseling (IC) and pre-separation briefing prior to submitting SkillBridge application. Complete the required TAP courses and mandated requirements to include TAP pre-separation and individualized IC requirements prior to submitting their SkillBridge application. **(T-1)**

4.1.4. Adhere to approval authority requirements and allowable training days by rank outlined in **Table 1**. **(T-1)**

Table 1. Rank-Training Length, and Approval Authority for USSF.

	CATEGORY 1	CATEGORY 2	CATEGORY 3	CATEGORY 4
RANK	E-1 toE-5	E-6 to E-8	O-1 to O-4	E-9, O-5 & above
TRAINING LENGTH	120 MAX	120 MAX	120 MAX	90 MAX
APPROVAL AUTHORITY	1st Field Grade CC w/ UCMJ	1st O-6 CC w/ UCMJ	1st O-6 CC w/ UCMJ	GO in CoC Approval

4.2. **General Guidance - Commanders will:**

4.2.1. Acknowledge backfill replacements are not authorized while their service member is participating in a SkillBridge training program. **(T-1)**

4.2.2. Follow approval authority categories by rank in **Table 1**, which must be authorized to impose non-judicial punishment under Article 15 of the Uniform Code of Military Justice (UCMJ) in the service member's chain of command. Authorization may not be delegated to a lower level. **(T-1)**

4.2.3. Ensure applicants complete the TAP initial counseling and receive Tier-level results to assess potential risk factors associated with their transition. **(T-3)**

4.2.4. Authorize requests when the service member is seeking SkillBridge participation in an industry program that directly supports a Secretary of Defense, Office of the Secretary of Defense, Secretary of the Air Force, Chief of Space Operations, or other administration or congressional priorities explicitly stated. Consideration should be given to the member's role and duties as an Active-Duty Guardian and participation may be denied in priority programs only if a member's participation would impact critical readiness and operational needs of the USSF.

4.2.5. Review TAP Tier-levels identified on the DD Form 2648, Section III, Item 15 as a consideration for assessing the requested SkillBridge Program. **(T-3)**

4.2.6. Prioritize service members identified as needing the highest level of support for successful transition to the civilian workforce. Additional consideration is given to service members with short notice transitions such as hardship discharge, medical board, or return from deployment. **(T-3)**

4.2.7. Require applicable modifications to SkillBridge Programs (e.g., fewer days, part-time, hybrid) when best suited for mission requirements, service member's needs, and training plans. **(T-3)**

4.2.8. Ensure any exceptions to policies in this Instruction are submitted with strong justification, applicable training plans, and any other documentation that supports the request as a rare exception. **(T-1)**

4.2.9. Release service members from unit duties during SkillBridge participation, place service member in Permissive Temporary Duty (PTDY) status, and update personnel duty status. **(T-1)**

4.2.10. Ensure that service members return to duty or are placed in the appropriate leave status when participating in part-time training. **(T-1)**

4.2.11. Require supervisors to maintain weekly communication with the participant and the training provider to monitor training progression according to the established training plan. **(T-1)**

4.2.12. Inform service members of any requirements to participate in unit formations, mission training, and other requirements as needed when remaining in the local area. **(T-1)**

4.2.13. Terminate SkillBridge participation due to changes in mission requirements, misconduct, lack of training progression, or reenlistment/extension, or retirement withdrawal. **(T-0)**

4.2.14. Require the service member to report to their unit or place them on a separate administrative leave status upon notification of termination or withdrawal from the SkillBridge Program. **(T-0)**

4.2.15. Require the service member to complete the online SkillBridge Exit Survey after completing their training to capture congressional reporting data-including job offers. **(T-0)**

4.2.16. Consider authorizing a second SkillBridge Program if the first training program is terminated for reasons outside of the service member's control. **(T-3)**

4.3. **General Guidance - USSF Service Members will:**

4.3.1. Acknowledge mission needs take precedence in the commander's decision to approve or disapprove the application. SkillBridge participation is not an entitlement. **(T-0)** Commanders may deny or modify applications (e.g., unable to support, reduce program lengths, or maximize terminal leave) if participation would directly impact critical readiness and operational need.

4.3.2. Complete the mandated TAP individualized initial counseling before applying for SkillBridge and complete all TAP mandates within established deadlines. **(T-1)**

4.3.3. Research DoD approved training opportunities aligned with their unique civilian career goals, training needs, and potential employment openings utilizing the DoD SkillBridge website (**https://skillbridge.osd.mil/**). **(T-0)**

4.3.4. Receive SkillBridge advisement/briefing if needed and complete virtual training and any other DoD preparation training required for participation. **(T-0)**

4.3.5. Review relevant ethics rules with emphasis on gifts, conflicts of interest, and post-government employment. **(T-0)** This may be accomplished through an ethics official interview.

4.3.6. Participate only with programs that do not create a conflict of interest, as defined in Title 18, USC, Section 208, *Acts Affecting a Personal Financial Interest*, Title 5, Code of Federal Regulations (CFR), Section 2635, Subpart D, *Conflicting Financial Interest* and *Joint Ethics Regulation*, or other Federal statute/regulation. **(T-0)**

4.3.7. Participate only with programs that do not involve an employer or business with which the Service member has a pre-existing relationship (e.g., previous employer, business owned by the service member, the service member's immediate or extended family, spouse, or spouse's family). **(T-1)**

4.3.8. Not extend their enlistment (enlisted) or Service commitment (officers) to participate in a Skillbridge Program and will immediately withdraw from their program if returning to duty to reenlist or extend their commitment(s). **(T-0)**

4.3.9. Complete all required separation/retirement actions (e.g., mandated TAP, obtain orders, out-processing, project authorized terminal leave, or PTDY) for relocation if eligible. **(T-1)**

4.3.9.1. SkillBridge applications may be submitted up to one year from planned Date of Separation (DOS) when supervisors and commanders verify the Expiration of Term of Service (ETS) date, official separation, or retirement approval notifications.

4.3.9.2. Separating service members will follow DAFI 36-3211, *Military Separations* and retiring service members will follow DAFI 36-3203, *Military Retirements*, as well as all other related myForce Support Squadron (myFSS) guidelines and timelines. **(T-1)**

4.3.9.3. When completing a SkillBridge Program outside of the local area (defined as 50 miles), requesting expedited orders is allowed 30 days prior to the final out-processing date. Online or local training programs are not eligible for expedited orders. **(T-1)**

4.3.9.4. SkillBridge PTDY and all other combined leave must be within 180 days from the DOS per DAFI 36-3003, *Military Leave Programs*, Table 4.3., Rule 23. **(T-1)**

4.3.10. Will submit projected dates in their SkillBridge application and upload their approved application in LeaveWeb as the PTDY source document. **(T-1)**

4.3.10.1. Service members may continue participating in their chosen SkillBridge Program during their terminal leave. Members may continue participating in their chosen SkillBridge program during terminal leave and beyond their DOS but will no longer be an official participant in the DAF SkillBridge program under the associated policies. **(T-1)**

4.3.10.2. Service members may accept job offers and hiring actions while on terminal leave.

5. Unauthorized Uses and Ineligibility Factors.

5.1. Service members are ineligible to participate in a SkillBridge Program under the following separation circumstances:

5.1.1. Service members under the Indispensability Program are not authorized to be removed from their critical position and are not eligible. **(T-1)**

5.1.2. When separating under the Career Intermission Program (CIP), this is a temporary status in which the service member returns with an Active-Duty Service Commitment (ADSC). **(T-1)**

5.1.3. When a permanently retired officer voluntarily returns to active duty and then reverts to their retired status, they are not eligible because this is not a standard separation or discharge as outlined in DoDI 1352.01, *Management of Regular and Reserve Retired Military Members*, paragraph 3.1.c.(4). **(T-0)**

5.2. Service members are only eligible for one SkillBridge Program during their career during the 180 days prior to the service member's transition out of active status. **(T-1)**

6. Service Member Application Procedures.

6.1. Service members will research, apply, and be selected for training with a DoD authorized organization prior to submitting their online application. **(T-1)**

6.2. Service Members will inform their supervisor and approval authorities referencing **Table 1** to discuss their intention to apply, desired SkillBridge Program, and projected training timelines. **(T-1)**

6.3. Service members will complete mandatory participation requirements to include the Air Force Virtual Education Center (AFVEC) Virtual Training prior to submitting their application. **(T-1)**

6.4. Service members will refer to the SkillBridge Personnel Services Directory Guide (PSDG) for additional details and instructions on submitting applications. **(T-1)**

6.4.1. Applications may be submitted in AFVEC up to one year from the DOS but not later than 30 days prior to the training start date for review and processing. **(T-3)**

6.4.2. Supervisor, appropriate commander, and additional reviewer (if applicable) email addresses are required on the application for correct routing via AFVEC. **(T-3)**

6.4.3. Orders, company agreement, training plan, and any other required documentation will be submitted as part of the online application for review. **(T-1)**

6.4.4. The applications must include all dates (e.g., PTDY Training, PTDY Relocation for House Hunting, if eligible, and Terminal Leave based on remaining projected leave). **(T-1)**

6.4.4.1. Service members may not begin a SkillBridge Program or other leave any earlier than 180 days prior to the DOS and will not end the leave in a SkillBridge PTDY status. **(T-0)**

6.4.4.2. Terminal Leave dates must be in conjunction with PTDY dates when out-processing the duty location and will be scheduled at the end of the overall program dates. **(T-1)**

6.5. Service members can monitor submitted application requests for status in AFVEC and will respond to system generated notifications throughout the application process. **(T-3)**

6.5.1. Final notification will be the approval of the Memorandum of Participation (MoP) or disapproval of the SkillBridge Program request. **(T-1)**

6.5.1.1. The MoP is the official approval document and must be uploaded into LeaveWeb and provided to supervisor, appropriate commander, and the SkillBridge provider. **(T-1)**

6.6. Service members will provide accountability, follow military training requirements, and maintain military standards while participating in a SkillBridge Program. **(T-3)**

6.7. Service members may report unresolved grievances/disputes regarding SkillBridge providers to their supervisor and commander and if needed, may elevate the complaints by submitting an official memorandum to AFPC SkillBridge Workflow for higher-level review.

6.8. Service members will complete the SkillBridge Exit Survey emailed to them upon termination or completion of their approved SkillBridge Program. **(T-1)**

7. SkillBridge Exception to Policy (ETP) Process.

7.1. An ETP must be submitted to SF/S1D via AFVEC for any policy requirements in this publication designated with a **T-1.**

7.1.1. Requests to deviate from policies outlined in **Table 1** will be submitted following guidance in the SkillBridge PSDG. **(T-1)**

7.1.2. Requests will include a memorandum with strong justification and commander indorsement, along with any other supporting documentation. **(T-1)**

7.2. ETPs will be approved when the requested SkillBridge Program supports Secretary of Defense, Office of the Secretary of Defense, Secretary of the Air Force, Chief of Space Operations, or other congressional priorities identified in the SkillBridge PSDG unless participation would directly impact critical readiness and operational needs of the USSF. **(T-1)**

7.2.1. The ETP will apply to any rank and can exceed program lengths in **Table 1**. **(T-1)**

7.2.2. These requests will only be denied by the approval authority if the service members' participation would impact the critical readiness and operational needs of the Space Force. **(T-1)**

7.3. Service members meeting a full Medical Evaluation Board (MEB) do not have an official separation date and must submit an ETP in AFVEC for approval and to establish an expected date. **(T-1)** Program lengths by rank in **Table 1** will apply to these service members if approved. **(T-1)**

7.3.1. Service members must establish estimated program timelines within 180 days from the MEB notification date, documented by the Form Letter 4 (FL-4). The medical codes must be redacted, and the FL-4 must be uploaded as the supporting documentation. **(T-1)**

7.3.2. Service members undergoing the MEB process will utilize the MEB ETP template memorandum provided in AFVEC Resources. **(T-1)**

7.3.3. MEB applicants must remain in the local area and be available for medical actions. They will not be approved for programs outside of the local area (50 miles). **(T-1)**

7.4. ETPs are not authorized for **T-0** paragraphs within this Instruction. (**T-0)**

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Performing Duties of Assistant Secretary of the Air Force for Manpower and Reserve Affairs

Attachment 1

GLOSSARY OF REFERENCES AND SUPPORTING INFORMATION

References

5 CFR § 2635, Subpart D, *Conflicting Financial Interest*

10 USC § 1143(e), *Employment Assistance*

18 USC § 208, *Acts Affecting a Personal Financial Interest*

32 USC § 502(f), *Required Drills and Field Exercises*

AFI 33-322, *Records Management and Information Governance Program*, 23 March 2020

DoDI 1322.29, *Job Training, Employment Skills Training, Apprenticeships, and Internships (JTEST-AI) for Eligible Service Members*, 24 January 2014

DoDI 1352.01, *Management of Regular and Reserve Retired Military Members,* 8 December 2016

DAFI 36-2681, *Voluntary Education Programs*, 17 December 2025

DAFI 36-3003, *Military Leave Program*, 5 May 2025

DAFI 36-3203, Personnel, *Military Retirements,* 28 January 2021

DAFI 36-3211, Personnel, *Military Separations,* 24 June 2022

DAFMAN 90-161, *Publishing Processes and Procedures*, 18 October 2023

Joint Ethics *Regulation*, 15 May 2024

Prescribed Forms

None

Adopted Forms

DD Form 2648, *Service Member Pre-Separation/Transition Counseling and Career Readiness Standards EFORM for Members Separating, Retiring, Release from Active Duty (REFRAD)*

Abbreviations and Acronyms

ADSC—Active-Duty Service Commitment

AFAEMS—Air Force Automated Education Management System

AFI—Air Force Instruction

AFPC—Air Force Personnel Center

AFVEC—Air Force Virtual Education Center

CC—Commander

CIP—Career Intermission Program

DAF—Department of the Air Force

DAFI—Department of the Air Force Instruction

DoD—Department of Defense

DoDI—Department of Defense Instruction

DOS—Date of Separation

E&TSC—Education and Training Section Chief

ETP—Exception to Policy

ETS—Expiration of Term of Service

FL-4—Form Letter 4 (FL-4)

HQ—Headquarters

JTEST-AI—Job Training, Employment Skills Training-Apprenticeships and Internships

MEB—Medical Evaluations Board

MoU—Memorandum of Understanding

MoP—Memorandum of Participation

PSDG—Personnel Services Directory Guide

PTDY—Permissive Temporary Duty

REFRAD—Release from Active Duty

SAF—Secretary of the Air Force

TAP—Transition Assistance Program

UCMJ—Uniform Code of Military Justice

USAF—United States Air Force

USSF—United States Space Force

Office Symbols

AFPC/DPPSA—Air Force Personnel Center Voluntary Education Business Process Owner

SAF/MR—Secretary of the Air Force, Manpower and Reserve Affairs

SF/S1—Deputy Chief of Space Operations for Human Capital

SF/S1D—Directorate of Force Development

USD (P&R)—Under Secretary of Defense for Personnel and Readiness

Terms

Apprenticeship—A combination of on-the-job-training and related instruction in which workers learn the practical and theoretical aspects of a highly skilled occupation. Apprenticeship programs can be sponsored by individual employers, joint employer and labor groups, or employer associations.

Employment Skills Training—Job skills training means training or education for job skills required by an employer to provide an individual with the ability to obtain employment or to advance or adapt to the changing demands of the workplace.

Internships—A system of on-the-job-training offered by a JTEST-AI provider to eligible service members to develop jobs skills and employment skills training that assists them to gain employment in the civilian sector.

Job Training—A method of preparing an employee to perform a task by providing them with information about the task, a demonstration of its performance, an opportunity for the employee to imitate the demonstration, and subsequent feedback.

Service Member—Any member of the United States Space Force.